endemic plant species and 42% of all terrestrial vertebrates.

India has 4 **biodiversity hotspots**: the Western Ghats, the Himalayas, the Indo-Burma region and the Sundaland [includes Nicobar group of Islands].

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CASE STUDY



Norman Myers (born 24 August 1934) is a British environmentalist specialising in Biodiversity **hotspots**. Professor Norman Myers was the first to alert global community to tropical deforestation, the mass extinction underway and environmental security.

Fact File

Endemism is an ecological word meaning that a plant or animal lives only in a particular geographical location, such as a specific island, habitat type, country or any defined zone. For example, The **Asiatic Lio**n of the Gir forest of Gujarat. The **Kashmir Stag** known as Hangul, which is found in the riverine forests of Kashmir Valley and Chamba in Himachal Pradesh. The **Lion Tailed Macaque** is India's most threatened monkey which is endemic to the Western Ghats of South India.

7.6 Endangered species

Rare, endangered or threatened plants and animals are elements of our natural heritage that are declining rapidly. If we cherish these species, like we do other rare and beautiful objects, these living organisms become treasures of the highest magnitude.

The International Union for the Conservation of Nature (IUCN) has identified and classified species based on the nature of their depleting numbers. The IUCN's Red List of Threatened Species, identified in 1964, is the world's most important inventory of the global conservation status of biological species.

Species are classified by the IUCN Red List into nine groups specified through criteria such as rate of decline, population size, area of geographic distribution, and degree of population and distribution fragmentation (Figure 7.11).

- Extinct (EX) – The species has disappeared and no known individuals remaining
- Extinct in the wild (EW) – Known only to survive in captivity, or as a naturalized population outside its historic range
- Critically Endangered (CR) – Species that have drastically dwindled and are at extremely high risk of extinction in the wild
- Endangered (EN) – High risk of extinction in the wild
- Vulnerable (VU) – High risk of endangerment in the wild
- Near threatened (nt) – Likely to become endangered in the near future.

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